

Official Rules of Cricket

A beginner's guide to understanding the game of cricket.

1. The Basics

Cricket is played between two teams, each consisting of eleven players.

The game is played on a circular or oval-shaped field with a rectangular 22-yard pitch in the center.

One team bats while the other team fields and bowls.

The objective of the batting team is to score as many runs as possible.

The objective of the fielding team is to dismiss the batsmen and limit the runs scored.

2. The Pitch and Equipment

The pitch is 22 yards long and 10 feet wide.

There are two sets of wickets, one at each end of the pitch.

Each wicket consists of three stumps topped by two bails.

The bat must not be more than 38 inches long and 4.25 inches wide.

The ball is a hard leather sphere with a circumference between 8.81 and 9 inches.

3. Scoring Runs

A run is scored when both batsmen successfully run to the opposite end of the pitch.

If the ball reaches the boundary rope along the ground, 4 runs are awarded automatically.

If the ball clears the boundary rope without bouncing, 6 runs are awarded.

Extras such as wides, no-balls, byes, and leg-byes also contribute to the team's score.

A wide is called when the bowler delivers the ball too far from the batsman to play.

A no-ball is called for an illegal delivery such as overstepping the crease.

4. Dismissals

A batsman can be dismissed in ten different ways in cricket.

Bowled: The ball hits the stumps directly and dislodges the bails.

Caught: A fielder catches the ball before it touches the ground after the batsman hits it.

LBW (Leg Before Wicket): The ball hits the batsman's leg in line with the stumps.

Run Out: A fielder breaks the wicket while a batsman is outside the crease during a run.

Stumped: The wicketkeeper dislodges the bails while the batsman is out of the crease.

Hit Wicket: The batsman accidentally knocks the stumps with the bat or body.

Handled Ball: The batsman deliberately handles the ball without permission.

Obstructing the Field: The batsman deliberately obstructs a fielder.

5. Overs and Bowling

An over consists of six legal deliveries bowled by the same bowler from one end.

After each over, the bowling switches to the opposite end of the pitch.

A bowler cannot bowl two consecutive overs.

In Test cricket, there is no limit on the number of overs per innings.

In One Day Internationals (ODIs), each team faces a maximum of 50 overs.

In Twenty20 (T20) cricket, each team faces a maximum of 20 overs.

6. Innings and Match Formats

In Test cricket, each team has two innings and the match is played over up to 5 days.

In ODI cricket, each team has one innings of up to 50 overs.

In T20 cricket, each team has one innings of up to 20 overs.

An innings ends when 10 wickets have fallen or the allotted overs are completed.

A team may also declare their innings closed before all wickets have fallen.

7. The Umpires

Two on-field umpires officiate the match, one at each end of the pitch.

A third umpire reviews decisions using video technology when required.

Umpires signal decisions using hand signals such as raising a finger for out.

Players can request a Decision Review System (DRS) review to challenge an umpire's call.

Each team is allowed a limited number of unsuccessful DRS reviews per innings.

8. The Fielding Positions

The fielding captain can place fielders anywhere on the field within certain restrictions.

In limited overs cricket, fielding restrictions apply during powerplay overs.

During the powerplay, only a limited number of fielders are allowed outside the inner circle.

Common fielding positions include slip, gully, point, mid-on, mid-off, fine leg, and square leg.

This document is intended for educational and ETL pipeline practice purposes.